

On the care of the self in artistic practices

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Abstract

In Western society of the beginning of the twenty first century most questions and relations are entangled with economy, and thereby to some degree mutilated. The power relations between the arts and the control structures of capitalism are, in an understatement, unequal. The possibility for interpretations of moral questions is shrinking. In only a little more than a decade the panoptic control structures of social-media have become second nature and they offer an understanding of ethics that is both normative and irrational. Departing from this rather dense scenario I will introduce ideas about how artistic practice in music can be part of a method with which a set of different values may be proposed. Values that may offer an interesting opposition, or tension, to those proposed by the dominant capitalist structures. These are not necessarily 'better' but can help to reveal how a multiplicity of perspectives can be applied to questions of what it means to make *good decisions* and be a *good human being*.

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Key words

Ethics, Experimental music, Artistic practice, Listening, Free play

Biography

Henrik Frisk is an active performer of improvised and contemporary music and a composer of electroacoustic music. As a professor at the Royal College of Music in Stockholm he is the head of programs for electroacoustic music and research. His own research is concerned with improvisation, interactivity, spatialisation and collaborative practices. Henrik has performed in many countries in Europe, North America and Asia, and as a composer he has received commissions from many institutions, ensembles and musicians. Numerous recordings, mostly collaborations, are available on American, Canadian, Swedish and Danish record labels.

The relation of the text to questions

- ▶ How can ethical perspectives in artistic research be related and analyzed in the context of artistic freedom? The text discusses how an ethics of artist practices can be understood and how it may be related to a more general understanding of ethics. The text argues that a multiplicity of ethical perspectives is important, and there is an opposing tendency towards a narrowing heterogeneity in hyper-capitalist societies structured in the logic of social media.
- ▶ What happens to the ethical framework when art moves into academia, and how is the question of artistic freedom then affected? At the end the I discuss how artistic research in some cases can appear to be in conflict with academic research ethics. This may happen in all research fields and it should not be seen as a problem, but an asset. Hence, artistic research is an arena on which the understanding of ethics may be expanded.

Ethics

The research in which this paper has been produced is performed as part of my employment at the Royal College of Music in Stockholm (KMH) and is following the code of conduct defined by KMH. All unnamed parties in the example discussed here are informed and have accepted to be part of the paper.

Introduction

It is fair to assume that both music and ethics lack a clear definition yet play an important role in the life of most people. They are necessary parts of the human condition and have been so for many thousands of years. There is also a strong connection between them as pointed out in the opening of the book *Music and Ethics* by Cobussen and Nielsen : "The relationship between ethics and music is one of the oldest topics in philosophical discussions of music dating at least as far back as Plato" (, Cobussen and Nielsen 2016, 1). The point I will pursue in this paper is that exploring ethics in artistic practice may complement traditional views on ethics in ways that may be of general interest. This could potentially have an impact on how artistic practices are esteemed in contemporary Western societies. The notion of the *Care of the Self* as discussed by Michel Foucault, mainly in *The History of Sexuality* (Foucault 1988)¹ is used as a method to approach this complex area.

The power relations between the arts and current capitalist and networked culture in the West of the 21st century, are unequal, to

Artistic practices in music

What may appear as a rather solipsistic activity of musical artistic practice—practicing an instrument for hours and hours, composing in solitude or improvising, or any of the related artistic activities—has in fact many similarities with the practice of the care of the self, and may therefore be explored through it. It should be noted that the ambitions of the latter are clearly much wider in scope, and artistic practice can only be said to be able to activate a small portion of what is constituted by the care of the self. The primary aspect of artistic practice here, as was noted above, is the way free play is employed, and as a consequence how freedom is developed. Since ethics, according to Foucault, is a form that freedom takes, artistic practice as a vehicle of free play, is a way in which ethics may be explored. That is to say that it is the activity of engaging in musical practice that holds the key to this investigation of ethical perspectives, and these may be different to the ruling ethical paradigms driven by contemporary society. The process is geared towards the promotion of perspectives that may encourage knowledge about the relation of oneself to oneself, informed by the

Concluding remarks

In their book *Music and Ethics* Marcel Cobussen and Nanette Nielsen state that music and ethics are "both indeterminate concepts, capable of referring to a variety of practices" (, Cobussen and Nielsen 2016, 3). This is in line with my argument here, although I would like to push this even further: it is *necessary* that we refer both music and ethics to a variety of practices, and that these practices are allowed to exploit a free play of associations. They also state that "once we begin exploring the area music *and* ethics the complexity increases exponentially" (, Cobussen and Nielsen 2016, 3) which may not always be true. The difference in our respective assessments is probably mainly due to the fact that their starting point and general perspective is slightly different from mine. The main difference being that my discussion is not concerned with ethics and music in general but rather constrained to the practice of making music and the ethical implications of this practice. Though still complex, by exploring ethics in and through musical practices a certain clarity may be revealed. The result may be an articulation that is embedded in

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